

MAYHEM BY THE MINUTE

Inside the fights that made 2025 one of the UFC's **wildest** years yet.

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As we head into the final couple of months of 2025, here's a look at the best Ultimate Fighting Championship (UFC) bouts of the year so far.

Holloway vs Poirier 3 — UFC 318

The trilogy fight between Max Holloway and Dustin Poirier (**above**) at UFC 318 was everything fans had hoped for — and the perfect send-off for Poirier's final walk to the Octagon. Holloway started at a blistering pace, hurting Poirier early, but 'The Diamond', roared on by a home crowd, fought back with sharp counters.

The final three rounds became a battle of volume versus precision — Holloway's endless output against Poirier's power shots. The two traded until the final horn, with Holloway edging a unanimous decision (48-47, 49-46, 49-46) to retain the BMF title, becoming its first successful defender.

Dvalishvili vs Nurmagomedov — UFC 311

In a gruelling bantamweight title fight at UFC 311, Merab Dvalishvili handed Umar Nurmagomedov the first defeat of his professional career with a unanimous decision (48-47,

48-47, 49-46). Nurmagomedov started brightly, displaying sharp striking and strong takedown defence, even wobbling the champion. But Dvalishvili's relentless pace and pressure told in the later rounds.

'The Machine' broke through in the championship rounds (last two), setting a new record for the most takedowns (97) in UFC history and overwhelming his tiring opponent. It was a masterclass in cardio and persistence, firmly cementing Dvalishvili's place as champion.

Imavov vs Adesanya — UFC Fight Night

Yet another short fight finds its way into this list. Nassourdine Imavov delivered a career-defining performance against Israel Adesanya at UFC Fight Night 250 in Riyadh, securing a stunning TKO victory just 30 seconds into the second round.

The opening round was competitive, but Imavov looked patient and measured, landing a significant uppercut that served as a precursor. In the second, 'The Sniper' moved swiftly, using a decoy jab to set up a devastating overhand right that landed flush on the former champion's chin. Adesanya fell backwards, and Imavov quickly followed with ground strikes, forcing the referee to step in and end the fight. The dominant finish marked Imavov's fourth consecutive win.



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KILLER BLOW



Ankalaev vs Pereira - UFC 320

Alex Pereira's stunning TKO win over Magomed Ankalaev at UFC 320 ended with 'Poatan' employing a barrage of strikes, including the 12-to-6 elbow.

This particular strike — a downward vertical motion of the elbow (as if moving from 12 to 6 o'clock) — was illegal under the Unified Rules of Mixed Martial Arts for over two decades, until last year.

The ban was controversially introduced due to the belief that this spiking motion delivered an unfairly concentrated impact, though it was often criticised as arbitrary, especially since virtually identical diagonal elbow strikes were always legal.

The long-standing ban was finally lifted in November 2024, making its use in Pereira's title defence entirely legal and highly impactful.